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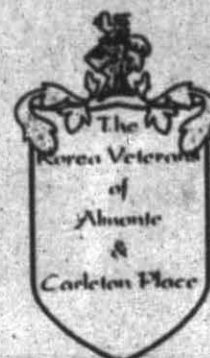
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The Almonte Gazette

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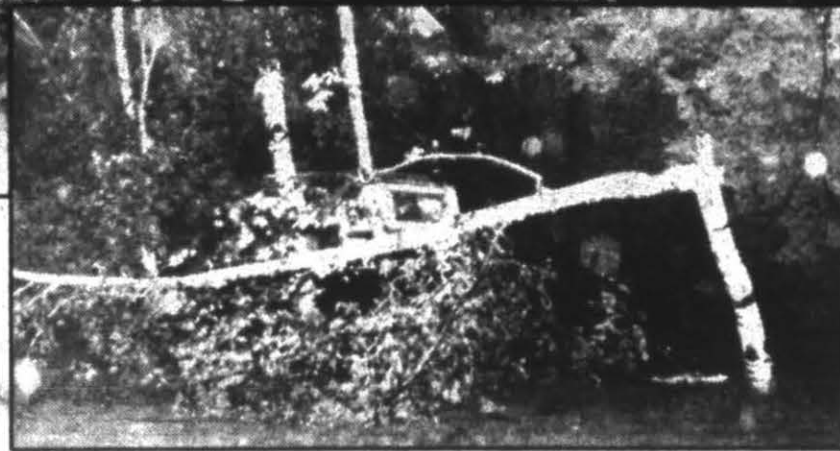
July 16, 1997

93° + 7° GST



Storm aftermath

The Monday afternoon twister which hit Thompson's Trailer Park in Clayton uprooted many huge trees, including this one which lies on Jack Thompson's truck. Meanwhile, damage to trees at Ray Thompson's sugar bush (inset) was also severe. Photos by June Dalgity.



Summer storm causes major damage and power outage in Clayton and Almonte areas Thompson's sugar bush sustains heavy loss

By Debora Dekok
 and June Dalgity
 Gazette staff

"We're very lucky."

Those words, spoken by Brian Gallagher of Almonte Hydro, reflect the sentiment of Almonte residents in the wake of the storm which blasted the area late Monday afternoon.

Strong winds and heavy rains left Clayton Lake and Middleville areas with damages to homes and cottages, while Westport and Glen Tay areas didn't experience any rain at all.

The Carp weather radar showed a very intense echo around the Almonte and Clayton Lake area which weakened in intensity as it headed south toward North Gower.

Many people who were alerted by radio reports warning of a possible tornado took cover. Almonte Gazette staff took refuge in the

newspaper's basement and were left without power or telephones, making production of this week's edition a challenge.

"We did not get any reports of sightings of a tornado," reported Paul Delannoy of Environment Canada.

But by Tuesday morning, calls from Clayton Lake flooded the office citing damages and downed trees.

A meteorologist was dispatched Tuesday to look at the trail of damage in order to classify the storm.

"At this point, we can't categorize the storm," said Delannoy.

In Almonte, hydro was lost for one hour and 20 minutes when a breaker on Country Street wouldn't reset. Almonte Hydro fixed the problem, but it occurred again, leaving the area in the dark for another hour.

"We lost a transformer and a

couple of line fuses. Power was out for close to two hours while we changed line fuses and changed the transformer," said Gallagher.

By Tuesday morning, only one or two streets were still without power. However, most of the Clayton area was still without hydro.

Mary Thompson, owner of the Thompson Trailer Park at Clayton Lake, said Monday's storm was the worst she had seen in the 59 years she has lived in Clayton.

She said before the storm hit, everything went completely white. When the torrential rains came, "it was a miracle no one was hurt."

"It was scary, I can tell you that."

Residents staying in the trailer park Monday night told Thompson they saw a funnel coming across the lake.

"They said it came down one way, turned and came back near the

water," she said.

Thompson's son Ray said a path of broken trees now runs through his sugar bush.

"I started counting the trees, but I gave up. There might be 40 per cent completely gone. They're twisted off or uprooted."

His other sugar bush nearby sustained no damage at all.

Uprooted trees were strewn across the park. A large maple tree totalling Jack Thompson's truck when it landed on the vehicle. One trailer in the park was completely destroyed by a fallen tree, while other trailers had minor damages.

Fortunately, most of the trailer park residents had gone home for the week.

"There are a lot of trees down. We're very fortunate it was on a Monday, not a Saturday," said Ray Thompson.

Transition board names new CAO for Mississippi Mills

By Ryland Coyne
 Gazette editor

First, the new municipality had to have a name. Now, local council members have established who will fill the two top jobs for the Town of Mississippi Mills.

Diane Smithson, who has been the Township of Pakenham's clerk-treasurer the past seven years, will take on the position of Chief Administrative Officer when the new municipality comes into being Jan. 1, 1998. Ross Trimble, Ramsay Township's clerk-treasurer/CAO the past decade, will assume the treasurer/deputy-clerk post.

The transition board (joint councils of Almonte, Pakenham and Ramsay) approved the appointments — on the recommendation of KPMG Consultants of Ottawa — during its meeting July 7 at the Ramsay hall.

Smithson said she was "thrilled" with the appointment.

"It's going to be an exciting challenge. I'm looking forward to it," she said.

The 30-year-old Blakeney resident spent 14 months as an administrative assistant at Ramsay before joining Pakenham in 1990. Before that, she spent three summers working in the Almonte town hall while attending Carleton University, from which she graduated with a Bachelor of Commerce.

She said she sees the key challenge will be to get the new municipality "up and running" as smoothly as possible. Ensuring services are not disrupted for residents will be another important component to the job, she said.

Marketing the new community to the public and making sure people are aware of the forthcoming changes is something that still requires work.

"We get people coming in here all the time, and they say 'See you next March,'" Smithson said, explaining the fact the central administrative office will be located at the present Ramsay building on Perth Road as of January.

Satellite offices will be maintained both in Pakenham and Almonte, she said. A recommendation from the finance and administration sub-committee to be presented at the July 28 board meeting, calls on the additional offices to be open on an "as needed basis". The Pakenham office will be open in conjunction with the village

library. The Almonte office will be run out of the town hall.

Busy position

According to the job description, the CAO's duties will include overseeing all department heads within the sprawling municipality, and ensuring implementation of "the objectives, policies and programs of council in accordance with applicable bylaws and regulations."

Attending council and committee meetings, preparing bylaws for council, running municipal elections, leading and motivating department heads are just a few other jobs on the list.

Ross Trimble refused to comment on the change.

At last Tuesday's Ramsay Township council meeting, Reeve Jim Lowry commended him for his work over the past decade.

"We had two really good candidates," he said. "There is a sadness here, Ross, that you didn't quite make it, but we'd like to thank you for your past contributions and hope you're around for years to come."

Other business

Meanwhile, the transition board also approved several other pieces of business at its July 7 meeting.

In addition to several other job descriptions, which were to be posted Friday, another \$25,000 was approved for the group's restructuring fund bringing the total to date to \$50,000. The money is needed to cover expenses during this transition process and is expected to be recovered from the province.

Ramsay deputy-reeve Cliff Bennett voiced his frustration over the fact no set budget has been approved by the board.

Almonte Reeve Paul Finner, who chairs the finance sub-committee, said he has no "crystal ball" and can't establish a firm budget at this time.

"We are reviewing and authorizing only those expenditures that are absolutely needed," he assured Bennett.

Pakenham deputy-reeve Brenda Hurrell said each of the sub-committees had been asked to submit budgets to finance. Once that is done, the figures can be tabulated and committees will work within

See CAO page 2

Almonte gears up for festival weekend

By Debora Dekok
 Gazette Reporter

There will be no shortage of things to do and sites to see in Almonte as the town's first Hoopfest kicks off this weekend. Hoopfest is a combination of the Almonte Business Area Ice Cream Festival and the Hallas/Naismith 3-on-3 Basketball Tournament.

Friday's downtown sidewalk sale starts the ball rolling, and events wind up 10 days later with the celebrity softball game in Gemmill Park.

Organizers from the Naismith Foundation and Almonte's Business Improvement Association (BIA) are ready for crowds.

"We just have to sit back and wait for the people to come," said Phil Wood, vice-president of the BIA.

"It has changed from the ice cream festival to a kind of a heritage thing."

The Almonte-Ramsay Fire Department's 30th anniversary will be celebrated with a street dance and fireworks Friday night.

On July 19, the historical textile museum puts on the lamb race, and a parade commemorating the Korean War veterans will be held that morning.

On the second last day of the festival, a Celtic Music Festival in Gemmill Park pays tribute to the Irish heritage of Almonte.

And the running of the balls July 26, the Basketball Camp from July 20 to 25 and July 27's 3-on-3 tournament honour the town's basketball heritage.

"The BIA approached us to move the 3-on-3 into July to help add energy to the Ice Cream Festival," said John Gosset of the Naismith Foundation.

Many more events have been added to make the first festival memorable.

"There is a lot of community involvement," said Wood. "We're all equal partners, rather than the BIA taking the lead. There's a lot of co-operation between the groups."

See page 14 of The Gazette for the Hoopfest 97 schedule.

Fire destroys one popular township attraction

By Theresa Fritz
 Special to The Gazette
 RAMSAY — It's been synonymous with Halloween for the past several years. But now it's no more.

The popular 'Haunted House' attraction at Countryside Petting Farm, RR 2 Almonte, was destroyed as a result of a fire Friday. The Almonte-Ramsay Fire Department was called to the scene, on the 4th Concession of Ramsay Township, around noon. They were soon joined by Mutual Aid fire companies including Carleton Place's Ocean Wave Fire Company, the Beckwith Township Fire Department and the Pakenham Township Fire Department.

According to Almonte-Ramsay Fire Chief Bill Lowry, the blaze began when a generator caught fire in a shed behind the house. From there, it spread to the house which quickly became totally engulfed in flames. No one was inside the haunted house at the time of the fire.

Lowry said there were no problems fighting the blaze but there was some concern about the adjoining bush area. He said the fire began spreading to the thick forest, but firefighters were able to extinguish it



Volunteers from the Almonte-Ramsay Fire Department attempt to extinguish the last of the flames amidst the smoking ruins of what once was the "Haunted House" at the Countryside Pet-

ting Farm on Ramsay Concession 4. Last Friday's fire is believed to have begun in the building's power generator building. (Photo by Chris Hashimoto)

before it got out of hand. Fire trucks were forced to travel through a field beside the petting zoo to reach the house which is located well back from Ramsay's fourth concession. Lowry said firefighters were on the scene until around 3:30 p.m. that afternoon.

The attraction is owned by Marg and Ron Henry. On Tuesday morn-

ing, she confirmed the house will be rebuilt. Although it will only be a replica of the 180-year-old home which stood there, it is expected to be operational by the fall.

"We put a lot of work into it," Henry said of the haunted house, which drew some thousand visitors a year.

"The day it caught fire, we had two big groups here ready to go through,"

she explained, adding that within a few minutes of the fire starting, the structure was engulfed in flames.

Insurance will cover the structural damage but not the contents inside the house. Henry estimated that damage to be around \$12,000.

Local children have begun a fundraising drive to help with the restorations costs, Henry added.